

Creating and Refining Technical Instructions: Troubleshooting a Wi-Fi Connection Issue on a
Windows 11 Laptop

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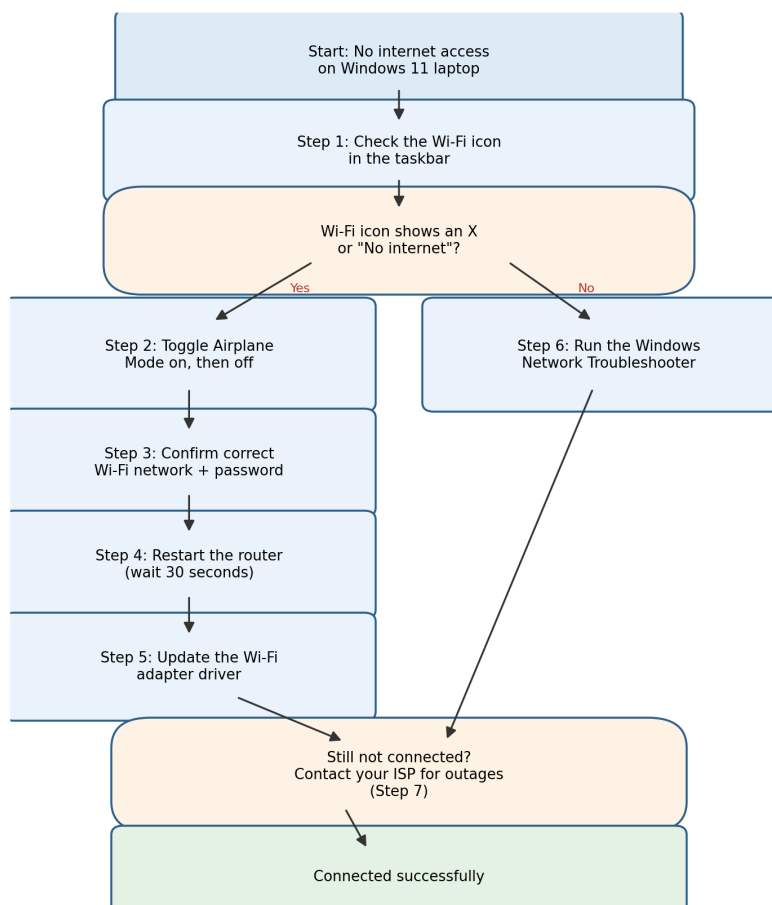
Introduction

Losing a Wi-Fi connection is one of the most common technical problems home computer users face, and it is often frustrating because the cause is not obvious. This document provides step-by-step instructions for troubleshooting a lost or unstable Wi-Fi connection on a Windows 11 laptop. The instructions are written for an everyday user with basic computer skills but no formal IT training, and they are organized so the user can follow each step in order, starting with the simplest fix and moving toward more advanced solutions.

Original Instructions

1. Check the Wi-Fi icon in the taskbar. Look at the bottom-right corner of the screen. If the icon shows an X or an exclamation point, your laptop is not connected to a network.
2. Toggle Airplane Mode. Turn Airplane Mode on for five seconds, then turn it off again to reset the wireless connection.
3. Confirm you are connecting to the correct network. Make sure you selected your own Wi-Fi network name and entered the correct password.
4. Restart the router. Unplug the router, wait, and plug it back in.
5. Update the Wi-Fi adapter driver. Go into Device Manager and update the driver for your wireless adapter.
6. Run the Windows Network Troubleshooter. Windows has a built-in tool that can automatically detect and fix common connection problems.
7. Contact your Internet Service Provider (ISP). If none of the previous steps worked, there may be an outage in your area.

Figure 1. Wi-Fi Troubleshooting Decision Flow



Testing and Feedback

To evaluate the effectiveness of these instructions, I asked a classmate to follow them exactly as written, without any additional verbal explanation, to troubleshoot a simulated Wi-Fi connection issue on their own Windows 11 laptop. I observed the process and took notes rather than intervening.

Several points of confusion came up during testing. First, my classmate was unsure what "toggle Airplane Mode" meant or where to find that setting, since the instruction did not name a specific menu path. Second, when reaching the router restart step, they were unsure how long to wait before plugging the router back in, so they plugged it in almost immediately, which did not

give the router enough time to fully reset. Third, the driver update step caused the most trouble: my classmate did not know how to open Device Manager and could not locate the wireless adapter once they got there, since the instruction assumed prior familiarity with that tool. Finally, they mentioned that a visual reference earlier in the document, rather than only at the end, would have helped them confirm they were on the right track.

Revised Instructions

Based on this feedback, I revised the instructions to include exact menu paths, specific wait times, and brief definitions of technical terms, and I added callout boxes to highlight steps that testers found confusing.

1. Check the Wi-Fi icon in the taskbar. Look at the bottom-right corner of the screen, near the clock. If the icon shows an X or an exclamation point instead of the usual signal bars, your laptop is not connected to a network.
2. Toggle Airplane Mode. Airplane Mode is a setting that turns off all wireless connections at once. Click the Wi-Fi/network icon in the taskbar, select the Airplane Mode icon to turn it on, wait five seconds, then click it again to turn it off. This resets your laptop's wireless connection.
3. Confirm you are connecting to the correct network. Click the Wi-Fi icon, and check that the network name (SSID) listed matches your home network. Re-enter your Wi-Fi password if you are prompted, making sure Caps Lock is off.
4. Restart the router. Unplug the router's power cable, wait 30 seconds (count slowly to 30), and then plug it back in. Wait about two minutes for all the lights on the router to turn solid before trying to reconnect.

5. Update the Wi-Fi adapter driver. A driver is the software that lets Windows communicate with your laptop's wireless hardware. Right-click the Start button and select Device Manager. Click the arrow next to "Network adapters" to expand the list, right-click the entry containing the word "Wireless" or "Wi-Fi," and select Update driver, then Search automatically for drivers.
6. Run the Windows Network Troubleshooter. Go to Settings > Network & Internet > Advanced network settings > Network troubleshooter, and follow the on-screen prompts. This built-in tool automatically detects and fixes many common connection problems.
7. Contact your Internet Service Provider (ISP). If you have completed all the steps above and still have no connection, call your ISP's support line to check for an outage in your area.

⚠ Tip: If your laptop still will not connect after Step 4, restart the laptop itself before moving to Step 5 — a simple restart resolves many lingering connection issues.

Reflection

Testing these instructions with a classmate revealed gaps that were invisible to me as the writer, largely because I already understood the task and unconsciously filled in details a first-time reader would not have. Kolin (2022) explains that effective instructions must be written with the audience's actual knowledge level in mind, not the writer's, and this testing process made that principle concrete rather than abstract.

The most significant change I made was adding exact navigation paths, such as "Settings > Network & Internet > Advanced network settings," instead of vague references like "go into your settings." Kolin (2022) identifies precise, concrete language as one of the primary ways to improve the clarity of a written step, and my classmate's confusion at the Device Manager step confirmed how quickly an instruction becomes unusable once it assumes knowledge the reader does not have. I also added a specific wait time for the router restart step. My original instruction simply said to "wait," but Kolin (2022) notes that instructions should quantify actions whenever possible rather than leaving readers to guess, and giving a concrete 30-second count removed that ambiguity.

I also added a callout box to flag a troubleshooting tip that was not part of the original numbered sequence but that testing showed was genuinely useful information. This reflects the document design guidance in Kolin (2022) that bolding, boxes, and other visual cues should be used to draw attention to critical information without disrupting the logical flow of the main steps. Similarly, moving the flowchart earlier and keeping it visible alongside the numbered steps addressed my classmate's comment that a visual reference helped them stay oriented, which lines up with Kolin's (2022) point that instructions are followed most successfully when they are effectively illustrated rather than relying on text alone.

This assignment taught me that technical writing cannot be fully evaluated by the writer alone. No matter how clear an instruction seems while drafting it, only a reader unfamiliar with the task can reveal where the logic breaks down. Testing forced me to replace assumptions with explicit detail, to quantify vague language, and to think about where a visual aid does more work than another sentence could. Going forward, I plan to build a testing step into any instructional

document I write, rather than treating it as optional, since it was the single most valuable part of this process for improving clarity and usability.

References

Kolin, P. C. (2022). Successful writing at work (12th ed.). Cengage.